INTERVIEW | MANISH TEWARI

"LEADERSHIP IS THE OMNI-PRESENT BUT INVISIBLE GORILLA IN THE ROOM"

Former Union Minister **Manish Tewari** was part of the 'Group of 23' who wrote to Sonia Gandhi in 2020, calling for an available, accountable leadership. In a conversation with **Kaushik Deka,** he outlines why Congress should rebuild its ideological and organisational framework. Excerpts



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Q. Why has the Congress not tasted national or state electoral success in the past eight years?
This is indeed why chintan and manthan are essential. The 10 years the UPA was in power between 2004 and 2014 consumed the collective energies of the leadership. The organisation did not get enough attention, especially from ministers in the UPA government. Much of the organisational atrophy witnessed from 1991 to 2004 could have been remedied had there been better cohesion between the Congress elements in the government and the party. Moreover, the generational change initiated in the highest echelons of leadership from 2011 onwards never fructified. A fair, transparent, and credible electoral process needs to play itself out. Those who can fight the BJP's juggernaut 24X7 and have spent 30-40 years in the service of the organisation need to come forward. The import of people from other parties and their installation in leadership positions need to be proscribed.

Q. The Congress has failed to come up with a clear narrative. At times, it promises financial inclusion with Nyay; at other times, it peddles soft Hindutva.
Every organisation requires five fundamentals that are moving parts but have to work in cohesion to ensure electoral and national relevance: ideology, narrative, organisation, access to resources and leadership. All five are a challenge in Congress's case today.

Q. Even though the Congress is accused of siding with minorities–or Muslims–even Muslim votes have deserted the party. Why?
That is the real tragedy of the past eight years. Everything unfortunately

omniscient, omnipresent, omnipotent strongman, versus the Opposition offering a team of experienced, capable and far more broadly representative leaders to serve the people. The one-man style has not served the country very well, as the nation's economic indicators confirm. A more broad-based alternative could do much better," he says.

Needed, a few good allies

The Congress leaders may like to believe that Rahul remains the prime challenger to Modi, but other Opposition leaders such as West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and Telangana chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao are challenging that certainty. All

REGIONAL LEADERS BLAME CONGRESS FOR ARROGANCE; IT DISMISSES THEIR 'EXAGGERATED AMBITION'

of them have directly or indirectly displayed their national ambitions and taken pot shots at the Congress leadership, particularly Rahul.

Nor does the Congress seem to be paying much heed